

Deep Dive: Supporting other Women: An Abundance Mindset

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We tend to want “good news” feedback. We like a lot of feedback as long as they're telling me how wonderful I am. And I have found that to be more true of women than men. And part of that comes from the way we were cultured. And it is changing generationally, thank heavens, but that starts with a time when I was coming up in my career that women weren't cultured in the same way.

We did not learn to play on teams like guys did. Little boys had t-ball teams and you would put them on a team and you'd prop that little ball up before they could hit a moving target. And they learned that it's OK if Johnny hits a home run today and Timmy hits it next week because we're all going for ice cream, and we're all going to win and it's a great thing.

Women didn't have that. So, when you went to school, it was about: “How did you look? And were you pretty? And were the boys going to like you? Who's going to be on the cheerleading squad where you're competing with other women? Who's going to be the homecoming queen?” When there's typically one. Then you get into a business environment where there aren't that many women.

And if you look at the numbers, and particularly as you get into director level and above positions, again, numbers are increasing and it's looking good. And I'm not suggesting we put anyone in a position who's not qualified for the position, but there are fewer examples and role models to follow. That's part of the issue -- who is around for you to emulate and learn from and apply to your leadership style and goals. This lack of opportunities to be cultured or to understand the rules of the game, if you will, in a business or an organization manifests itself in various ways.

I've watched and studied women in meetings and men in meetings. Men will argue and debate and at the end of the debate, smack each other on the back and say, let's go for a burger and a beverage. Women leave, and we tend to take it more personally and we take it as a personal attack and then won't talk to that person or we will say terrible things about that person to others for six months to a year or longer because we haven't learned to separate and attack *issues* and not *individuals*. It's about, “We're solving a problem. We're dealing with an issue. We leave the individual their respect.”

In organizations, it's sometimes tough to not see other women as competition because we feel like there are fewer opportunities and that women are only going to get a certain percentage of those opportunities. Instead of looking at it as: “What can I do? How do I equip myself? How do I give myself the skills and the reputation? And how do I deliver the goods -- in other words, *get results*, so that people see me in that role.”

So, we tend to look throughout organizations, again, in academia, in business, in non-profits, and we see another person, and we think there's only a handful of us that are going to get to the next level, and we tend to then not work together, but we often don't optimize each other in our strengths because we see each other as competition.